

Regular Meeting
September 11, 2017
School Committee Meeting
Caron Theater
Medford High School

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the Caron Theater at Medford High School at 7:04 p.m. Those present were Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson.

A moment of silence was held on the anniversary of 9/11. Mr. Skerry remembered Medford resident John Doherty who lost his life on 9/11.

A moment of silence was also held for all the victims of Hurricanes Harvey and Irma.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno that the minutes of June 19, 2017 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

It was asked if a date has been set for a Committee of the Whole regarding School Brains. Mayor Burke answered that Dr. Perella is present tonight so we will set a date. Ms. Kreatz asked about extended hours at the library. Superintendent Belson answered that the library will open earlier this year and the new hours should begin in a couple of weeks. Ms. Kreatz voiced concerns regarding the merger of MHS/MVTHS. She and many parents and students were under the impression that the vocational school was to keep its own identity through the merger with the high school. She stated that everyone is confused. They recently learned that the assistant principal and guidance counselor are now housed in the high school. Also student ranking is now incorporated with the high school. Ms. Kreatz made a motion to discuss further at the next meeting. Superintendent Belson replied that the merger has been talked up for a while and is hard for everyone to understand. It brings change. However, the vocational school is governed by Chapter 74. The merger gives high school students along with vocational students the chance to explore. Change is difficult. Perhaps a Committee of the Whole is necessary to further discuss. Ms. Cugno stated that the goal is to give students the chance to explore both schools. She is surprised to hear the changes that are taking place. It is very concerning. Ms. Cugno said she would second the motion to have a meeting to discuss. Ms. Van der Kloot commented that the details are clear to administration but not to the school committee. There are lots of questions and Ms. Van der Kloot looks forward to further discussion. Ms. DiBenedetto said that she has advocated for vocational school student to be present on stage at graduation and to see this disappear is very sad for her. These students need to be celebrated. We need to look at the details and ways to better communicate to parents and students. Thanks to Ms. Kreatz for bringing this forward. Mr. Skerry said that he shares the concerns with his colleagues and has received many call. He is in favor of scheduling a committee of the whole meeting.

On the motion of Ms. Kreatz seconded by Ms. Cugno to have a Committee of the Whole to further discuss the merger of MHS/MVTHS:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Ms. DiBenedetto questioned the line item payment to Attorney James Collins. Kirsteen Patterson replied that it was for arbitration.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Community Participation

Mayor Burke informed the citizens wishing to speak that we are awaiting the arrival of our attorney and will take item out of order when he arrives.

Report on Opening of Schools SY 2017-2018

Superintendent Belson stated that school year 2017-2018 officially began on Tuesday, August 29th for students grades 1-12 and for kindergarten students on Wednesday, September 6th. Overall, it was a good opening. As usual there were a few items that required adjustment. Administration, faculty and staff invested substantial time and expertise to get a positive result. This evening you will hear specific reports that document the opening. Additional reports will be forthcoming in the weeks ahead. As a school committee you have been very supportive.

Please note the following:

- Significant maintenance and construction around the district was accomplished. Various individual school projects will continue during the next few months. The new multimedia studio was completed. Bistro 489 is about a month away from operational completion. Additional parking has been added to the high school complex replacing the skateboard park. A number of capital fund projects will be advanced this fall.

- Class sizes are very good throughout the district. You have a detailed chart in your materials.
- New members of our management team have been hired and have made an excellent transition. Major positions including the Vocational Technical Principal/Director, the ELL Director, Brooks Assistant Principal, Director of Fine Arts, McGlynn Middle Assistant Principal, and Director of Technology have assumed their roles seamlessly.
- We have hired 62 new personnel this year to fill vacant slots and to enhance our programs. A listing is attached to this opening report.
- Our Elementary Science Program has substantial new materials and we are actively piloting a new textbook series.
- Each school is receiving a minimum of 50 new Chromebooks with charging carts to enhance our technology utilization.
- We have expanded our library staff to support expanded hours at the high school and better access at the k-8 program.
- The middle schools have more foreign language this year.
- The additional health teacher at the middle school will ensure that all students have access to the Michigan Model. A special grant from the Attorney General's funds will enhance our opioid prevention education initiative.
- A special grant from the Cummings Foundation will support expanded citizenship and community service education.
- A grant from the State Treasurer will support a new financial literacy initiative entitled *Credit for Life*.
- Our Global Scholars program will be expanded and we will participate in an international symposium.
- Our high school/vocational school merger is moving forward to the benefit of all 9-12 students. Over 240 students will explore CTE program options this year.
- We have maintained a comprehensive curriculum that offers a full range of courses to students. Art and music have been enhanced not cutback.
- Once again we have finished the year with a balanced budget despite federal and state cutbacks.
- We are working collaboratively to increase the inclusivity of all our programs.
- Our Early Childhood Programs are among the best in the state. The Family Network is a wonderful resource to our young families. We have excellent before and after school programs available.

Each new year brings challenges. This year is no exception. I am confident that we will meet our challenges and make progress in all areas of your school system.

- MCAS 2.0 will be in full force in 2018. A new test using some different format requires our attention.

- Federal and State finance is uncertain. Expanded attempts at privatization and reductions in key line items will require resourceful creativity to meet our needs.
- A growing number of EL students will require modified programs that are responsive to the needs of those learners.
- Expanded demands for technological capacity will require investment.
- Spring 2018 will see a new Coordinated Program Review of our district by DESE. We will be ready.
- Applications for additional capital projects to improve our facilities will require substantial planning and follow thru.
- Review and adoption of several policies aligned with new laws and regulations.
- The potential transition of key personnel will require planning and recruitment.

Beyond the above concerns it is important that we recognize that schools are more than academic institutions. The recent Phi Delta Kappan poll of the public's attitudes toward the public schools made the following statement, "Academic achievement isn't the only mission. Americans overwhelmingly support investments in career preparation and personal skills." Medford has consistently advocated for the "whole child" and "youth transition to adulthood." We must continue on the path. Another key concern today is "media literacy." We must help our students to develop the media literacy necessary to counteract the hateful ideas, rhetoric, and behaviors that are emerging unchallenged. The late Senator Daniel Patrick Moynihan said, "You are entitled to your own opinion, but you are not entitled to you own facts." Opinion has become as true as facts today. The September edition of the Atlantic Monthly explained it this way. The internet and competing media outlets allows us to create communities that reinforce our preconceived beliefs with or without evidence .Holocaust survivor Ellie Wiesel said "The opposite of love is not hate. It is indifference." Our most important curriculum must be a curriculum of caring. As we begin a new school year, we must re-dedicate ourselves to truth, love, and human development as well as academic proficiency. We cannot be indifferent. Our students and our community need us to stand up. We need to help each other meet the challenge. There is no better time than the present to embrace a curriculum of caring! We can do it.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno urged the Superintendent to schedule a Committee of the Whole meeting to discuss the middle school enrollments. She thought that the numbers were to be evened out this year. Superintendent Belson stated that they are working on this now and the plan is to implement it next year. Ms. Mustone questioned the difference in enrollment numbers in the elementary totals. Ms. Caldwell explained that kindergarten was not included in the figures.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno the report was accepted and placed on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Administrative Meetings and Induction of New Teachers

Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli updated the committee on the new teacher induction program. The program was designed to introduce our new educators to the district's policies and procedures; to familiarize them with curricula programs and technological applications; and most importantly, to acclimate them to Medford as a "caring educational partnership of school, family and community. Various workshops were held during the four days. Feedback from the week has been overwhelmingly positive. There were suggestions for next year that will be incorporated into the program. Deputy Superintendent continued with an overview of the administrative meetings that what were at the same time. Ms. Nelson stated that most of the administrators had been working throughout the summer hiring new staff, preparing materials, reviewing preliminary state test results and scheduling students and staff. Many topics were covered related to the opening of school and events that will occur this year.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept report and place on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Enrollment and Class Size

Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell presented the report. She stated that it is still very early in the school year but the elementary class size is excellent. The Roberts had been provided with two additional classes. The enrollments in the Andrews are higher than the McGlynn and an action plan to help balance our numbers is being prepared now. Additionally information will be provided as the year progresses.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto commented that class size is in great shape overall across the district. The Columbus School has low numbers perhaps moving a program to that school could be looked into going forward. Ms. DiBenedetto said that the requested reports section was not included and she would like it kept on the agenda. She would like a report on how the new developments will/are affecting enrollments. Superintendent Belson commented that as of now there has been very little change in enrollments. He also said that when programs are moved it effects transportation.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Mr. Skerry to receive a report at the next meeting regarding the effect of the new real estate developments on school enrollment:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Mr. Skerry asked about the status of the Locust project. Mayor Burke answered that it is in land court and there has been no decision by the judge. Ms. Van der Kloot said that her biggest concern is that parents are upset that middle school students did not get first choice. She would like these students followed this year to make sure that they are adjusting and doing ok. She would like the discussion of the middle school selection place of the agenda for a future meeting.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry the middle school selection process will be placed on agenda for a future meeting:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Ms. Kreatz questioned why the high school and vocational enrollments are combined and requested a breakout of the numbers.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Report on Buildings and Grounds Projects

Director of Buildings and Grounds John McLaughlin presented the report. He said he is pleased to say that he had a very busy and successful summer accomplishing various projects throughout the district. Two custodians were hired to replace retirements. He read the list of repairs completed at the various schools. He thanked the Department of Corrections the DPW and park department for their assistance this summer.

Discussion:

Mr. Skerry said that the staff did a great job on the Curtis Tufts floor, it looks like it did years ago. Ms. Van der Kloot asked who did the ceiling repairs. Mr. McLaughlin answered that a professional plaster. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if we have a power washer is it possible to do the windows. Mr. McLaughlin answered that he would research it. Ms. Cugno asked about the high school bathrooms. Mr. McLaughlin said that the petitions were replaced a couple of years ago. The elementary petitions need replacing in the very near future. Ms. Kreatz asked when the opening is scheduled for the Bistro. Superintendent Belson answered that a little more time is needed to allow for necessary training.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Report on Transportation

Director of Finance and Administration Kirsteen Patterson presented the report. She stated that this is year three of a three-year contract with Eastern Bus Company. There are 17 regular routes that service all Medford Public Schools along with St. Joseph and St. Raphael Schools. One bus was saved in the Minuteman transportation with the use of a smaller minivan through Ride Rite transportation. All routes continue to be reviewed for efficiencies and accommodations where safety is the main priority.

Discussion:

Ms. Kreatz commented that she is happy to hear about accommodating the high school students with yellow buses next year before MBTA buses begin. She asked why Salem St. was chosen as a pick up spot this year. Ms. Patterson answered that when making the accommodation, one of the drivers saw many students waiting along Salem Street. Ms. Mustone asked how many students use the bus daily. Ms. Patterson said that it varies from day to day. Ms. Mustone said she is curious and would like the numbers. Ms. Kreatz asked about the Fulton bus and the overcrowding issue. Ms. Patterson said there are two buses but they leave at the same time. Ms. Kreatz asked if the MBTA route schedule could be posted on the website. Ms. Patterson said they could post the link to the site.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Mustone the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot the rules were suspended to take papers out of order for Community Participation.

Cheryl Knowles was given permission to speak. Ms. Knowles, who shares custody with her ex-partner, requests permission for her two daughters to attend Medford Public Schools. Superintendent Belson explained that he has a copy of a court order and until there is a new order he will not be in contempt of court. Discussion with Ms. Knowles and her partner continued with the School Committee regarding this matter. Attorney Greenspan said that he would not enroll the children in Medford until we receive a decision of the court. Attorney Greenspan will look into petitioning the judge for a decision.

Report on Before and After School Programs

Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell presented the report. Ms. Caldwell reported that the Before School Program has been up and running since the first day of school. Information was sent home to families in June regarding the programs and information was posted on the Medford Public Schools website. Much planning and organization was done over the summer months. Families were given a handbook with pertinent information. Ms. Caldwell continued with the after school program which continues to flourish in Medford. All of our families are pleased that we offer not only homework assistance but special projects and activities after school. Each school has a site coordinator, a group leader and assistant group leaders.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept report and place on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve Amendments to Electronic Device Utilization

Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson presented the report. Ms. Nelson reported that last spring administration developed and the School Committee approved a policy related to student use of electronic devices. Upon further review, high school administrators determined that one segment of the policy would be difficult to enforce. This item dealt with student use of cell phones/electronic devices in the hallways between the passing of classes. The approved policy has very specific sanctions for violations. We need to ensure that if we are imposing sanctions that they be administered consistently and equitable. The Headmaster is recommending that we amend the policy to allow for use of these devices in the hallways during passing time. Since students are not all necessarily in the cafeteria during lunch periods the new amended policy speaks to the use of electronic devices during lunch periods in “designated student areas” to include the gym and library in addition to the cafeteria. We have also added language to the policy that speaks to the needs of students on specific education plans at all grade levels.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno stated that she has a problem with use in hallways during passing time. Ms. DiBenedetto said that she agrees with the changes and makes a motion to approve. Dr. Perella said that they have reached out to many communities and none of them enforce a policy. Ms. Van der Kloot asked Dr. Perella about recruiting a student representative to the school committee this year.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry the Medford School Committee replaces the current Electronic Device Policy with the Amended Electronic Device Policy:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve the Medford Public Schools Dress Code Policy

Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson presented the report. She stated that last spring a review of the various dress codes began. This review showed that the dress codes among the schools were inconsistent and that several were outdated. The issue of dress code is being discussed by educators all over the state. Dress codes that are too specific or restrictive could be challenged by a parent in a court of law. State law mandates that students dress must comply with reasonable standards of health, safety and cleanliness and must not cause a distraction or disruption in the educational process.

Discussion:

Ms. Mustone asked if this policy would replace the existing ones in the McGlynn and the Andrews handbooks. Ms. Nelson answered that the policy will be in all handbooks.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to approve the Medford Dress Code Policy:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve Revised Student Activity Accounts Policy and Practice
Director of Finance and Administration Kirsteen Patterson presented the report. Ms. Patterson reported that the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education has updated procedures and guidelines that recommend new acceptance of the current laws and regulations. The governance of these accounts falls under Ch. 71 Section 44 as amended by Special Acts of 1996 Ch. 66. This revision identifies the City Treasurer to establish checking and savings accounts under the designation of building Principals. There are currently checking accounts for each school which is under the direction of the Principal. Treasury has established applicable savings accounts for each school to provide grader interest earnings and reconciliation by school. A vote is requested to approve the provisions of MGL Ch 71 S47 as amended by Ch 66 of the Special Acts of 1996 to establish the threshold for sweep accounts into each school account.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked if the proposed amount is enough for the high school. Ms. Patterson answered that it is the intent to be replenished monthly or biweekly as needed. Ms. DiBenedetto asked for clarification on what this is for. Ms. Patterson explained that it is for each school to use for clubs, fundraising etc.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry, seconded by Ms. Kreatz to approve the provisions of MGL Ch 71 S47 as amended by Ch 66 of the Special Acts of 1996 to establish the threshold for sweep accounts into each school account.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Report on School Brains Software and Implementation

Superintendent Belson reported that a comprehensive report on the School Brains software and implementation in Medford has been prepared. School year 2016-2017 was the first full year of this program in our school system. Conversion from I-Pass to School Brains was a major undertaking and it is reasonable to expect some bumps in the road. Also, the interaction between a management software package and the myriad of longstanding, specific policies and practices could not be untangled overnight. Overall the School Brains software system has been a major improvement.

Based upon our experience during year one we are making adjustments that will address the issues that emerged in year one. There will be certain policy decisions that must be made to avoid other concerns. For example:

- Should a weighted GPA system be continued in any format?
- Should special awards for achievement be based upon GPA related ranking? Are there other ways to make determinations?
- How can we allow optimum access to student records and still provide optimum privacy/security?
- How can we promote advanced student learning that is not driven by GPA style ranking?
- How can we systematically increase parental participation in the communication opportunities offered by School Brains?

The above questions will be addressed in the next few months as we seek to effectively assess student learning and properly value their achievements. The report and data was prepared by Curtis Tuden in conjunction with the Superintendent and the management team. Mr. Tuden continued with an overview of School Brains strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and liabilities.

Discussion:

Mayor Burke asked about the transfer of data regarding the GPA of a student. Mr. Tuden answered that it was determined that an error was made and a correction has been made. Mayor Burke asked if this was a manual error and if there are checks and balances or is it up to the student and/or family to discover an error. Mr. Tuden replied that there is always a chance of error but it has been rectified so this should not happen again. Ms. Kreatz was concerned because if a grade is entered incorrectly it causes much stress on both the student and the parents. Ms. DiBenedetto stressed the importance of correcting incorrect GPA's for students. It is very important as they begin to apply to colleges. Dr. Perella said that they are corrected and updated and the transcripts have also been corrected. Ms. DiBenedetto asked about the teachers contract negotiations and what is their obligation regarding School Brains. Superintendent Belson answered that when teachers were negotiating they indicated that they did not want to input information daily and on multiple sites. They can update weekly. As they grow they will become more comfortable with School Brains. Ms. Van der Kloot questioned the liabilities and notification of rights. She would like to try to address/resolve some of the liabilities and recommended sending to subcommittee for curriculum to discuss further. Mr. Skerry suggests having a Committee of the Whole meeting very soon.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto to send to Committee of the Whole for further discussion:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Negotiations and Legal Matters including Executive Session tabled until the next meeting.

New Business:

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Joan Gorman. Mrs. Gorman was the mother of School Committee member Erin DiBenedetto.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Carl Galusi. Mr. Galusi was the father of Medford teacher Matt Galusi and father in law of Principal Suzanne Galusi.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Mitchell Chester. Mr. Chester was the Commissioner of the Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Rosemarie Alfe. Mrs. Alfe was a former Medford High School secretary and the aunt of Public Information Officer Lisa Evangelista.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Annina Scaramuzzo. Mrs. Scaramuzzo was the mother of the Director of Foreign Languages Rita DiCarlo.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Robert Murray. Mr. Murray was the godfather of city hall employee Lisa Cacio and the uncle of school committee member Erin DiBenedetto.

On the motion of Cugno seconded by Ms. Mustone the meeting was adjourned at 10:17 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Respectfully submitted:

Paulette Van der Kloot
Secretary

